



(Scenes from)

1. **Mahabhoj**
(Mannu Bhandari, 1982)

2. **Tughlaq**
(Girish Karnad, 1964)

3. **Charandas Chor**
(Habib Tanvir, 1975)

4. **Court Martial**
(Swadesh Deepak, 1991)

IT WAS ONLY AT THE END OF THE 20TH C. THAT THE DALIT QUESTION BEGAN TO INFORM THEATRE: *COURT MARTIAL* WAS ITS KEENEST POINT

things differently and continually encountering failure is one narrative that has not changed.

In the '70s and ' 80s, Indian theatre witnessed a turn in its core idiom and intent wherein attempts were made to satirise modern storytelling by using elements from the folk and classical theatrical repertoire. If one has to choose among them, Vijay Tendulkar's ***Ghasiram Kotwal*** (1972)—powerfully deploying the expressive toolkit of traditional stagecraft, right down to *abhang*s and *lavani*s, for its depiction of the amorality and corruption of power—makes a niche for itself.

Habib Tanvir's ***Charandas Chor*** (1975) did something similar. Originally composed in Chhattisgarhi, it is based on the story *Fitrati Chor* (Inherent Thief) by Rajasthani litterateur Vijaydan Detha. When the play was first performed with Chhattisgarhi artistes, speaking and singing in their own language, it capped Tanvir's long quest to dismantle the formal protocols of theatre in order to give it a new lease of life.

The last two decades of the 20th century will forever be remembered for three plays—Swadesh Deepak's ***Court Martial*** (1991), Mannu Bhandari's ***Mahabhoj*** (Great Banquet, 1982) and Asghar Wajahat's ***Jis Lahore Nai Dekhya O Jamyai Nai*** (One Who Has Not Seen Lahore Has Not Even Been Born, written in the 1980s). Though all three were written in Hindi/ Hindustani, their story, temperament and staging gave them a distinct and unique identity.

Uniquely, Mannu Bhandari first composed a novel with a political narrative, then adapted it for the theatre herself. Since its first staging in 1982, *Mahabhoj* has been performed several times. In fact, the theatrical version became so popular that people nearly forgot that Bhandari had initially written it as a novel. Needless to say, this play is living proof of the extent to which politics can go to fulfil its ulterior motives.

In 1989, Wajahat's *Jis Lahore Nai Dekhya O Jamyai Nai* got etched in theatre history overnight. The tragedy of Partition is a theme that emerges time and again in our literature and arts. Here, Mai's humane character exists almost as nature's defiance of binary political codes—no wonder the play has resonated with audiences in India and Pakistan alike, besides of course the diaspora.

It was only in the last decade of the 20th century that the Dalit question materialised in any appreciable form in Indian theatre. *Court Martial* was one of its sharpest expressions; it has not only grown in esteem and popularity since its first staging, but has remained in perpetual discussion. An interesting exercise, then, to sift through the archives and identify 10 landmarks; for it's clear history remembers only those works that remain relevant through the ages. ■

(This piece has been translated into English by Chandrali Mukherjee)